Real Options help you keep your options open until you have enough information to act; Deliberate Discovery helps you get this information. If you actively try to increase your knowledge in this area, you can both reduce the risk of uncertainty and make decisions faster; remember, as soon as you know enough to commit to a particular solution, you can choose to exercise your option or not.

But Deliberate Discovery also has broader applications. For example, suppose you've decided to implement a particular feature and have broken it down into a number of stories. Some of these stories may seem straightforward, and others may not be so simple.

The natural tendency is to implement the simplest stories first, and there are good reasons why you might do this. But reducing your ignorance should be high on your priority list. Wherever possible, identify the stories that involve the most uncertainty, and tackle these ones first. Then review the remaining stories, keeping in mind what you've learned and considering the feedback the stakeholders give you. This simple approach can go a long way in helping you increase your knowledge and understanding in areas that matter.

EXERCISE 4.3 Raj, Joe, and Susan used both Real Options and Deliberate Discovery to decide on the best way to implement the password-strength feature. Discuss how.

4.5 From examples to working software: the bigger picture

In BDD, conversations around an example mark the first step in actually building and delivering a feature or story. You don't have this conversation until you're committed to implementing the corresponding functionality. But once you do, you kick off a process that will hopefully lead to putting a useful new feature in front of your users (see figure 4.19).

The process starts when you choose a story to work on and select one of the acceptance criteria to implement ❶. Next you discuss this acceptance criterion with the relevant stakeholders, using examples to explore the problem space, as we discussed in the previous section ❷. These conversations should produce a better understanding of what the user needs, and a set of examples, or scenarios, to illustrate the acceptance criterion.

Different types of conversations

In practice, conversations about features and examples can take many forms. For example, teams that are new to BDD often benefit from workshops early on in the iteration, where the whole team, including business stakeholders, is involved. These workshops are a great way to get communication happening sooner rather than later, to give the team a shared understanding of the features they're building, and to produce a set of high-quality examples. On the downside, they can be hard to organize and are expensive in terms of people-hours.

A more lightweight approach, which can work well when teams start to become more experienced in BDD, is known as the "Three Amigos." Three team-members—a developer, a tester, and a business analyst or product owner—get together to discuss a feature and draw up the examples. For this to work well, all three need to be reasonably familiar with the problem space, but the dynamic interaction of each role is often very